



90 |

world's third largest book fair that I recently visited, is a far cry from the 'small-town-feel' Emirate of 1986. Little wonder 11% of tourists in Sharjah are Indians, behind Russia and China.

The Sharjah Biennial (from February to June), now in its 16th edition, enriches the Emirate's cultural landscape with newly commissioned installations. This edition features 650 artworks by more than 200 artists spread across 17 venues. Similarly, the Sharjah Light Festival that concluded in February had renowned artists from across the globe using its stunning architecture, including the Sharjah Mosque and Al Rafisah Dam as a backdrop, for displaying lights, colours, and music.

Another star attraction from Sharjah Art Foundation is the Rain Room (tickets for 25 AED, around ₹580). This permanent immersive installation in the Al Majarra area uses 2,500 litres of recycled water controlled through

**Sharjah
distinguishes
itself from
its glitzy
neighbours
by preserving
its Emirati
heritage through
distinctive
architecture and
culture**

special 3D tracking cameras. It requires you to trust the technology and walk through pouring rain without getting wet! It's quite an experience because you have to fight against your basic instinct to run through the rain. If you run, you get wet, as I did! The installation is the brainchild of Random International, an art group based in London and Berlin, and was previously on show at London, New York, Shanghai, and Los Angeles.

Walking through the narrow alleys of Al Mareija, a sense of history envelops you. Here, between the Arabian Sea and the Gulf of Oman, a maritime civilisation was born. Today, Sharjah's original city centre celebrates its vibrant heritage through a renovated creekside district called Heart of Sharjah that reflects what Sharjah has been through history. Explore the diverse art galleries and museums, take in the traditional architecture, buy souvenirs at local souks and drink Arabic cof-